available in our repository, so they are never all cleared. This `minimum_count` setting ensures that those three snapshots are never deleted, even if they are older than one week. Similarly, the `maximum_count` setting ensures that we have no more than the given number of snapshot copies (6, in this case), even if they are younger than seven days.

6 Review the options, and create the SLM policy.

MANUALLY EXECUTING SLM

We don't need to wait until the scheduled time in the policy to kick-start the snapshot action. If we have weekly snapshots scheduled in the policy and need to make a backup due to a production hotfix, we can use a manual start. The following listing shows how to manually execute the SLM policy by invoking the `_execute` endpoint on the API.

Listing 14.12 Manually executing scheduled snapshots

```
POST _slm/policy/prod_cluster_daily_backups/_execute
```

Running this command starts the previously created `prod_cluster_daily_backups` policy instantly. We don't need to wait for its scheduled time.

Searchable snapshots (Enterprise edition)

In version 7.12, Elasticsearch introduced a brand-new feature called *searchable snapshots*. This functionality helps run search queries against snapshots. The idea is to use backups as indexes for certain queries. Because snapshots can be written to low-cost archival stores, not just using them to restore data but also mounting them effectively as indexes to run search queries is a big win.

We know that adding replicas to the cluster is one way to improve read performance, but there is an associated cost: replicas cost time and money due to the extra space they require. By making snapshots mountable (using the `_mount` API), they are available for searches, effectively replacing replicas and thus reducing our costs by almost half.

The searchable snapshots feature is available only for Enterprise licenses and is not free with the basic license. For this reason, we don't cover them in this book. If you're interested, check out the documentation for details on how to implement searchable snapshots (http://mng.bz/XN7M).

Elasticsearch works by convention over configuration, leaving us with fewer decisions to make when working with the setup or running Elasticsearch and its operational side. However, running the system on defaults is asking for trouble. We must tweak the configuration when needed to provide additional memory or improve performance. We discuss high-level settings, what they mean, and how we can change them in the next section.